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The New Year awaits a world on the edge of chaos



MIDDLE EAST | P9

Syria steps up engagement with the world

Dubai rolls out commercial drone delivery

HAMDAN PLACES THE FIRST ORDER MAKING HISTORY IN URBAN LOGISTICS

DUBAI
BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

Residents, based or those working out of Dubai Silicon Oasis (DSO), can soon have a drone deliver their food orders – or even medicines or other essential items – in what is Middle East’s first-of-its-kind drone delivery system.

Shaikh Hamdan Bin Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE, and Chairman of The Executive Council of Dubai, launched the drone delivery system by placing the first order from the Rochester Institute of Technology-Dubai. The order was delivered from one of the take-off points in DSO.

Shaikh Hamdan said: “Furthering Dubai’s leadership in future mobility, we launched the Middle East’s first-of-its-kind drone delivery system today. We have directed teams to expand the system’s coverage to 33 per cent of Dubai. I thank all government entities and private sector partners who helped make this pioneering project a success.”

Aside from the Rochester Institute of Technology, the drone delivery system will also serve locations such as Dubai Digital Park, making it one of the two

We have directed teams to expand the system’s coverage to 33 per cent of Dubai.”

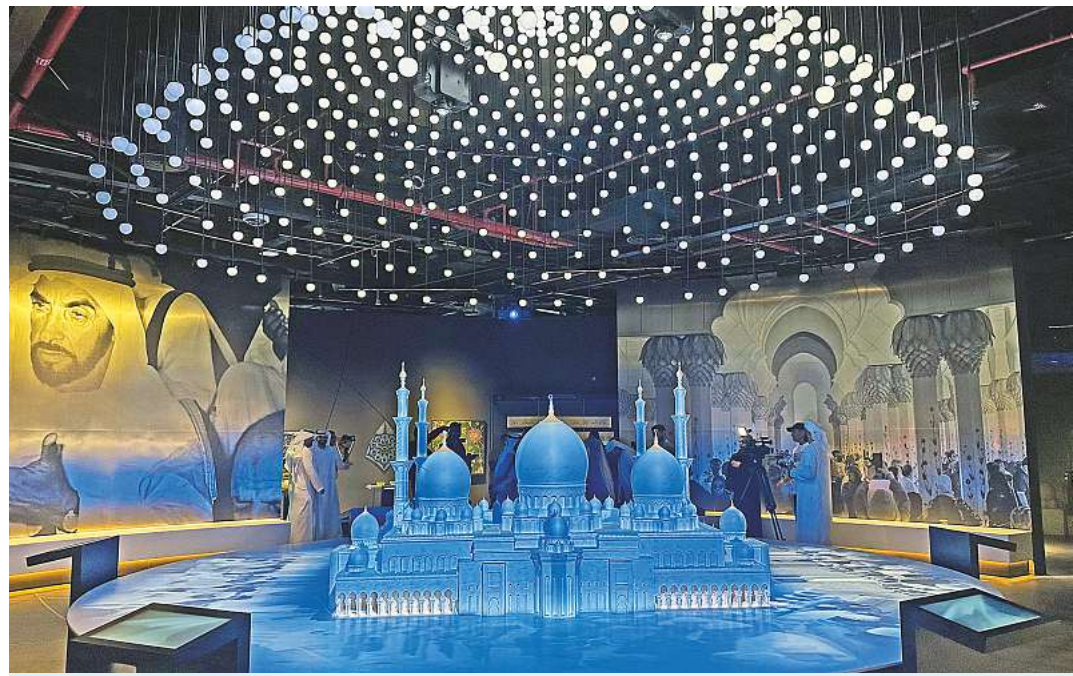
Shaikh Hamdan Bin Mohammad

landing points within DSO’s drone delivery network. The commercial services will be deployed on four operational routes in DSO.

The launch at DSO, the special economic zone for knowledge and innovation and a member of the Dubai Integrated Economic Zones Authority (DIEZ), was also attended by Shaikh Ahmad Bin Saeed Al Maktoum, President of the Dubai Civil Aviation Authority, Chairman of Dubai Airports, Chairman and Chief Executive of Emirates Airline and Group, and Chairman of DIEZ.

The launch comes as China’s Keeta Drone got the first commercial licence issued in the UAE for ‘Beyond Visual Line of Sight’ drone deliveries from Dubai Civil Aviation Authority. The company is part of Chinese tech firm Meituan. (The ‘Beyond Visual Line of Sight’ use refers to deploying drones beyond the operator’s immediate visual coverage.)

SEE ALSO P4



Afra Alnofeli/Gulf News

LIGHT AND PEACE: NEW MUSEUM OPENS IN ABU DHABI

The new Light and Peace Museum at Shaikh Zayed Grand Mosque Centre opens to the public today, showcasing rare Islamic relics. The latest attraction in the UAE capital is housed in the Dome of Peace at the Grand Mosque Centre. The museum will be open daily from 9am to 10pm and offers its content in seven languages: Arabic, English, Chinese, Spanish, French, Russian, and Hindi. **REPORT ON P4**

UAE car dealers offer 0% financing

Buyers also benefit from strong year-end deals

DUBAI
BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

In the UAE, dealerships are offering enticing promotions for new car purchases, with a popular option being zero per cent financing for up to five years. This offer is increasingly being pushed by banks for popular car brands like Toyota, Audi, and Volkswagen, often with a required 20 per cent down payment. The financing terms are

typically shorter, ranging from three to five years, and some additional fees may apply. The recent rate cuts by the US Federal Reserve not only led to a rollback of the high auto financing rates of 2022 and 2023, but lower loan rates also pushed up spending in 2024.

Surge in inquiries

Also, the buying trend will persist into the start of 2025, banking industry sources reveal. Car dealerships in the UAE are already seeing a surge in inquiries and are optimistic about finishing 2024 strong, and unlike previous years when supply issues limited

availability, new cars are being delivered promptly.

Some dealerships are also offering multi-year insurance coverage as part of the deal, addressing concerns about rising insurance costs. This is why, experts evaluate, the UAE car market is seeing renewed consumer confidence, with favourable financing rates encouraging purchases.

Additionally, car rental demand is picking up, driven by an influx of tourists and expatriates, particularly for SUVs and sedans. Experts also predict that these trends will support a strong end to 2024 and a positive outlook for 2025.

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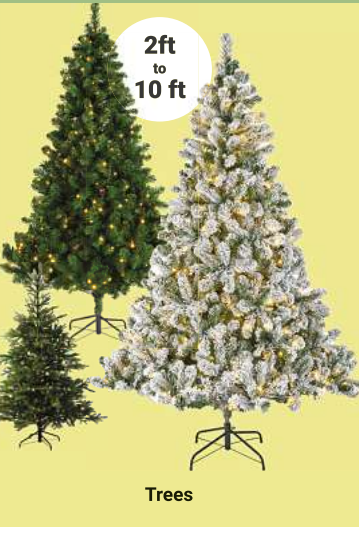
Tablecloth, Placemats, Ceramic items
Serving Tray sets & Disposable items



Hats, Headbands, Glasses & Outfits



Acrylic LED Figurines



2ft to 10 ft
Trees



Baubles (3cm to 30cm) & Ornaments



Gifting Collection



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